Module 1
Introduction to Modern Art & Ideas

Module 2
Places & Spaces

Introduction to Places & Spaces
- Welcome to Module 2 — Reading • 10 min
- Places & Spaces — Video • 4 min

Real and Imaginary Places
- How do artists choose to represent the world? — Reading • 20 min
- Martin Wong. Stanton near Forsyth Street. 1983 — Video • 1 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Zarina. Home is a Foreign Place. 1999 — Video • 2 min

Experiencing a Place
- How do artists capture the mood of a place? — Reading • 10 min
- Claude Monet. Water Lilies. 1914-26 — Video • 1 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Emeka Ogboh. Lagos State of Mind. 2017/2020 — Video • 2 min

Reimagining a Place
- How do artists reimagine architecture? — Reading • 10 min
- Teddy Cruz, Fonna Forman. Manufactured Sites: A Housing Urbanism Made of Waste/Maquiladora, project (Model, 2005). 2005-2008 — Video • 2 min
- Carolina Caycedo. Spirals for Shared Dreams. 2022 — Video • 4 min

Review & Reflect
- Optional Readings & Resources — Reading • 10 min
- Assessment: Places & Spaces — Dialogue • 15 min
- Optional Prompts for Discussion & Reflection — Reading • 10 min

Module 3
Art & Identity

Module 4
Transforming Everyday Objects

Module 5
Module 5: Art & Society

Module 6
Course Conclusion

How do artists choose to represent the world?

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Hippolyte Blancard. *Untitled*. [illegible]



Hippolyte Blancard. *Untitled*. August 1888. Platinum print, 8 13/16 × 6 1/8" (22.4 × 15.6 cm). Purchase.



Hippolyte Blancard. *Untitled*. October 1888. Platinum print, 8 13/16 × 5 7/8" (22.4 × 15 cm). Purchase.



Hippolyte Blancard. *Untitled*. April 1889. Platinum print, 8 15/16 x 6 1/8" (22.7 x 15.6 cm). Purchase.

The Paris of today took shape in the late 1880s. The wholesale modernization of the medieval city—a vast public works program overseen by Baron Georges-Eugène Haussmann—was nearly complete. This coincided with La Belle Époque, a period of invention, art production, and relative peace. In 1887, construction began on the Eiffel Tower, the latest technological and architectural marvel that was built to serve as the entrance to the 1889 Exposition Universelle (World's Fair). Pharmacist and amateur photographer Hippolyte Blancard was there with his camera, documenting the tower's rise. The platinum prints he produced span from July 1887 to April 1889 and detail different stages of the tower's construction, from the assembly of its pyramidal base to its pointed tip. Blancard's images capture the making of a symbol of a rapidly changing city, one met with both awe and resistance in his time, as Parisians reacted to the new world developing all around them.

Manhatta (1921)
The Museum of Modern Art

Watch on

Paul Strand, Charles Sheeler. *Manhatta*. 1921

In 1921, Sheeler and Strand collaborated to make *Manhatta*, considered to be the first American avant-garde film. Inspired by Walt Whitman's poem "Mannahatta," which is quoted in one of the intertitles, the film portrays life in New York City in sixty-five shots. These sequences cumulatively display one day in Lower Manhattan, beginning with a ferry approaching the city in the early morning and ending with a sunset view from a skyscraper. Using extreme camera angles, the film captures the dynamic new metropolis activated by people coming and going.



Salvador Dalí. *The Persistence of Memory*. 1931. Oil on canvas, 9 1/2 x 13" (24.1 x 33 cm). Given anonymously. © 2016 Salvador Dalí, Gala-Salvador Dalí Foundation/Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York

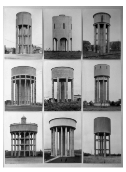
With melting pocket watches and a mask-like figure in a barren landscape, Salvador Dalí's *The Persistence of Memory* may seem wholly imaginary. However, the scene sprang not only from the artist's imagination, but also from his memories of the coastline of his native Catalonia. As he once explained: "This picture represented a landscape near Port Lligat, whose rocks were lighted by a transparent and melancholy twilight; in the foreground an olive tree with its branches cut, and without leaves." Dalí applied the methods of Surrealism, tapping deep into his dreams and subconscious for many of the forms that populate this painting. These are set against aspects from the real world, including the rocky ridge in the painting's upper-right-hand corner, which resembles the cliffs of the Cap de Creus peninsula.



Leonora Carrington. *And Then We Saw the Daughter of the Minotaur*. 1953. Oil on canvas. 23 5/8 × 27 9/16" (60 × 70 cm). Gift of Joan H. Tisch (by exchange) © 2024 Leonora Carrington / Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York

After seeing an exhibition of Surrealist art at age 19, Leonora Carrington traveled to Paris to meet some of the artists and poets associated with the male-dominated artistic circle. She asserted, "I didn't have time to be anyone's muse…I was too busy rebelling against my family and learning to be an artist."

A few years later, she moved to Mexico City, a setting that cultivated her passion for mythology and the unknown, and her discovery of methods for cooking and healing that were new to her. In her painting *And Then We Saw the Daughter of the Minotaur*, she depicts her two small children, Gabriel and Pablo, among columns, mystical creatures, and crystal balls, possibly awaiting an act of divination. Bubbles reflect the surrounding light and make visible what's beyond, architectural details peer through the clouds near the top of the painting. Over the course of her eight-decade career, Carrington continued to explore the mystery of the world around her, claiming at the end of her life, "The only thing I know, is that I don't know."



Bernd Becher and Hilla Becher. *Water Towers*. 1988. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gelatin silver prints, 67 11/16 x 55 1/8" (172 x 140 cm). Gift of Werner and Elaine Dannheisser. © 2016 Hilla Becher

Husband-and-wife team Bernd and Hilla Becher spent more than 40 years seeking out and photographing examples of European and American industrial architecture—including grain elevators, blast furnaces, and oil refineries—that were starting to disappear in the transition from an industrial to an information society. The nine water towers in this gridded arrangement are just a handful of the hundreds they photographed over the course of their career.

In order to capture their subjects with the utmost precision and clarity, they used a large-format camera and finely grained, black-and-white film, photographing them frontally and under overcast skies. The Bechers then classified the subjects in their photographs by function and displayed their images in grids, so that the individual structures could be compared. "We studied this anonymous architecture, object after object, until we understood the enormous variety of the subject," Hilla Becher has said.



Jeff Wall. *After "Invisible Man" by Ralph Ellison, the Prologue*. 1999-2000. Silver dye bleach transparency; aluminum light box. 5 ft. 8 1/2 in. × 8 ft. 2 3/4 in. (174 × 250.8 cm). The Photography Council Fund, Horace W. Goldsmith Fund through Robert B. Menschel, and acquired through the generosity of Jo Carole and Ronald S. Lauder and Carol and David Appel © 2024 Jeff Wall

Jeff Wall based this elaborately staged photograph on the prologue of Ralph Ellison's celebrated 1952 novel, *Invisible Man*. The novel's protagonist, an unnamed African American man, relates that he lives secretly "in my hole in the basement," where he has "wired the entire ceiling, every inch of it" with 1,369 lights powered by illegally siphoned off electricity. In addition to the prologue, Wall drew from other parts of *Invisible Man* and his own imagination to create this scene. His intention was not to make a literal illustration of the text, but to give form to the picture it inspired in his mind. As he has explained, many of his images begin "from accidents in the street—events I witnessed by chance. These pictures are like that, except that the accident occurred when I happened to be reading a book."

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